

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ARMENIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

In Armenia the fight is usually about a mine, and underneath the mine it is almost always about water. A small, mountainous, semi-arid country with a mining-dependent economy sits on top of the aquifers, rivers and reservoirs that its towns, farms and famous spas depend on — and a gold or copper-molybdenum project can put the two in direct collision. The most important thing to understand at the outset is that ordinary people here have already stopped a nearly finished mine. When the communities of Jermuk and Gndevaz blockaded all four roads to the Amulsar gold project in June 2018 — a project that was roughly three-quarters built, into which a UK- and Canadian-linked company had poured hundreds of millions of dollars — they held it for more than two years, drove its international financiers out, and left its future unresolved. That is not a promise that you will win. It is proof that the outcome is not settled in advance. Armenia's mining boom runs straight through its water: gold at Amulsar above the springs of a famous spa town and the reservoir chain that feeds Lake Sevan; copper-molybdenum at Kajaran in the deep south; a suspended mine in the cleared forest of Teghut; gold on the eastern border at Sotk. In each, the same collision recurs — a valuable ore body beneath, or beside, the water and the land that ordinary people live on. This guide is about how those ordinary people have fought, and sometimes won.

This guide is a practical manual for communities, activists and residents who want to stop, shrink, delay, or force real changes to a harmful project — a mine, a tailings dam, a hydropower scheme, a quarry, a smelter, a road, a landfill, a large agricultural or tourism development. It is grounded in how the Armenian system actually works: its environmental-assessment law, its permitting bodies, its courts, its Ombudsman, its distinctive tradition of physical community presence, and its unusually strong reach to international financiers and accountability mechanisms. It is honest about the constraints too — an economy that leans on mining, a government that backs projects it deems strategic, and the investor-state arbitration threat that companies use to frighten governments away from listening to you.

The Strategic Framework

Winning rarely comes from one masterstroke. It comes from combining pressure on several fronts so that a project becomes slower, costlier, riskier and more embarrassing than it is worth. Five moves reinforce each other: **identify** the project and its weak points precisely; **document** everything to a standard a court, a regulator and a foreign bank will respect; **organise** a rooted local core and widen it into a national and international coalition; **use the legal openings** the environmental-assessment law and the courts provide; and **carry the story** to the public, the press and the financiers. No single step is reliable on its own. Together they have repeatedly turned confident projects into stalled ones.

Critical Caveat: Which Situation Are You In?

Be honest, early, about the terrain, because it changes the strategy.

The more open situation: the project is a private commercial venture, its assessment has real defects, the water or tourism stakes are visible, and the government is not personally committed to it. Here the full toolkit works — public participation, the courts, community resolutions, the Ombudsman, financier pressure, and the press.

The tilted situation: the government treats the project as strategic (a major mine, an energy scheme, a flagship investor), the permits are already issued, and officials publicly champion it. Here you discount the odds of an outright legal stop and shift toward delay, documented illegality, community resolutions, financier and reputational pressure, and the international spotlight — the combination that has moved even government-favoured projects.

Most Armenian fights sit between these poles, and most move along the spectrum as they go. Amulsar began with a prime minister saying the mine was almost certain to open; it ended with the financiers gone and the project frozen. Read your situation as it is, and re-read it as it changes.

How to use this guide

Start with Steps 1 and 2 — identify and document — because everything else rests on them. If you have little time, jump to the Rapid-Fire Version (Section 12); if the deck is stacked, read Section 13 first. The email and letter templates (Section 11) are meant to be adapted, not copied word for word. Verify the current name of each body and the current deadline before you act — Armenia reorganises its ministries and amends its assessment law, and names change.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot exploit a process you do not understand. Here is the machinery a project must pass through, who runs it, and where it can be gripped.

The Bodies That Decide

The Ministry of Environment (the former Ministry of Nature Protection) is the central authority for environmental impact assessment and expert examination, and the body whose conclusions and permits a challenge ultimately targets.

The "Environmental Impact Expert Examination Center" — the state expertise body (a state non-commercial organisation) — carries out the technical expert examination of a project's assessment and issues the **expert conclusion**, positive or negative, that a project needs before it can proceed. That conclusion is the single most important document in the whole process, and its defects are the heart of most legal challenges.

The mining and subsoil authorities — the ministry responsible for territorial administration and infrastructure and its subsoil agency — grant the subsoil-use rights and mining permits under the Subsoil Code. A large mine therefore needs two things you can contest: the environmental expert conclusion, and the mining/subsoil permit.

The Environmental Protection and Mining Inspection Body is the inspectorate — the body that is supposed to police compliance, illegal works, and permit conditions once a project is underway. It is where you report a company that drills, clears or builds without the right permit.

Local self-government matters more than newcomers expect. Community councils (the elected council of a municipality) and the provincial administrations (marzpetaran) have defined competences in the assessment process, and a community's own resolutions carry real political and moral weight — Jermuk's council unanimously moving to ban metal mining in its area was a turning point at Amulsar. Land use, communal land, and local consent run through these bodies.

The Cabinet and the Prime Minister enter when a project is treated as strategic. Their public backing is the strongest signal that you are in the tilted situation; their silence or hesitation is an opening.

A practical note on the expertise body: it works to statutory timeframes (a preliminary stage of assessment runs to a defined number of working days, and an incomplete application must be returned for correction), and it can issue a **positive** or a **negative** conclusion, or a positive conclusion **with conditions**. Those conditions are a lever in themselves — they are enforceable, and a company that breaches them is exposed. The inspectorate's real-world record is uneven: it has often been slow to act against favoured operators, which is precisely why your own documentation of a violation, filed formally, matters — it puts the failure to enforce on the record too. And since the 2023 amendments, provincial administrations and elected local self-government bodies have **defined competences** in the assessment process, which means their formal positions are not merely political but part of the legal machinery you can invoke.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

A project moves through recognisable stages, and each is a place to intervene. First, the initiator submits the proposed activity for a **preliminary assessment / screening**, which sorts it into one of three categories by the severity of its likely impact: **Category A** (large-scale, significant impact — mining, chemical industry, metallurgy, large energy and waste facilities all fall here), **Category B**, and **Category C** (least). A mine is almost always Category A, which means the fullest assessment and expert examination — and the most public-participation rights for you.

Next, the initiator prepares the **assessment documentation** (the "mainframe paper" — the environmental impact assessment report). This goes to the state expertise body for **expert examination**. Crucially, the law requires **public notification and public consultations** at defined points: the initiator and the authorities must inform affected communities and hold hearings, and you have the right to submit written comments and objections that must be considered. Then the expertise body issues its **expert conclusion**. Only with a positive conclusion can the project obtain its construction and, for a mine, its subsoil-use permit. Each of these — the categorisation, the adequacy of the assessment, the genuineness of the consultations, the conclusion, and the permits — is contestable.

Two stages deserve special attention. The **categorisation** decides how much scrutiny a project gets: an operator that gets a large project classed as Category B or C, when its true scale and impact make it Category A, has quietly escaped the fullest assessment and your fullest participation rights — challenge a soft categorisation early. The **public consultation** is where projects are most often legally vulnerable, because the law's requirements are specific (timely public notice, genuine hearings, a real chance to comment, and a duty to consider what you say) and are frequently met only on paper. If the notice was buried, the hearing was held far away or at short notice, or your written objections were never addressed, you have documented a breach of both the statute and the Aarhus Convention — one of the most reliably winnable grounds there is.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Matter

The core statute is the **Law "On Environmental Impact Assessment and Expertise" (Law HO-110-N)**, adopted in 2014, in force since August 2014 and amended since (including a significant 2023 revision that clarified the competences of provincial and local self-government bodies). It sets the categories, the assessment steps, the public-participation duties, and — importantly — provides that disputes arising in the process are **appealed in court**. Around it sit the **Subsoil Code** (2011), which governs mining and subsoil-use rights; the **Land Code** (2001) and the laws on local self-government, which govern land and community consent; the **Water Code** and the law on **specially protected nature areas**, which matter enormously where water, protected zones or forests are at stake; and the **Constitution's** commitments to a healthy environment. Armenia is also a **Party to the Aarhus Convention** (ratified in 2001), which guarantees rights to environmental information, public participation and access to justice — a treaty you can cite directly, and whose compliance committee has heard Armenian cases. The **Freedom of Information Law** (2003) backs your right to the file.

The supporting codes matter in specific fights. The **Subsoil Code** governs the grant of subsoil-use and mining rights, and a mine that lacks a valid subsoil-use right, or that operates outside its boundaries or conditions, is acting unlawfully. The **Water Code** and the water-permit regime govern abstraction and discharge — vital where a project will draw down or pollute a river, spring or reservoir. The law on **specially protected nature areas** bars or restricts activity in reserves, national parks and sanctuaries, and a project that touches a protected zone or a forest carries extra, contestable consents. Armenia's **Aarhus** obligations are not merely aspirational: the Convention's compliance committee has examined communications concerning public participation and access to justice in Armenia, and you can invoke both the treaty and its findings when the domestic process falls short.

Two practical points. First, the law's public-participation and information rights are real and enforceable — inadequate consultation is one of the most common and most winnable defects, and it was central to the international findings against Amulsar. Second, the assessment must actually assess the real risks; a report that ignores the water pathway, the tourism economy or the seismic and acid-drainage risks is a defective report, and its defects are your case.

Follow the Money — Why Projects Proceed

Mining is a pillar of Armenia's export economy, and that is why projects proceed against local opposition: royalties, taxes, jobs promised, and foreign investment. The investors are often international — Amulsar's Lydian was UK- and Canada-linked; other major operations trace to foreign and diaspora capital and to firms like GeoProMining and the Zangezur Copper-Molybdenum Combine. This internationalism is a vulnerability as much as a strength: foreign-listed and internationally financed companies answer to shareholders, lenders and reputational risk that a purely domestic operator would not. Amulsar drew money from the **IFC** (the World Bank's private arm) and the **EBRD** — and both eventually exited, which is one of the most important things that ever happened to the project. Learn who funds and who profits, because

the financier is often the softest and most decisive pressure point.

Know the landscape. Armenia's flagship metal operations include the vast **Zangezur Copper-Molybdenum Combine at Kajaran** in Syunik — one of the country's single largest industrial enterprises and export earners — alongside gold and copper operations run by firms such as **GeoProMining**, the now-suspended **Teghut** copper-molybdenum mine in Lori, and gold mines including **Sotk** in the east. Metals and mining make up a large share of Armenia's exports, which is exactly why the state treats the sector as strategic and why individual projects proceed against local opposition. But the same internationalism that makes the sector powerful makes it reachable: foreign owners, foreign listings, international lenders and diaspora scrutiny all create pressure points a purely domestic operator would not have.

The Overseers — Who Can Hold the System to Account

Several bodies can check the machinery. The **Human Rights Defender (Ombudsman)** of Armenia can examine administrative failings, rights violations and environmental complaints, and issue findings that carry public weight. The **courts** — the **Administrative Court** for challenges to administrative acts and permits, up to the **Court of Cassation** — are, since the 2018 changes, meaningfully more independent than in much of the region, though still uneven. The **Prosecutor's Office** and the police can be pressed to act on illegal works. The **Audit Chamber**, the **National Assembly** and its committees can scrutinise money and policy. And uniquely powerful in Armenia are the **international accountability mechanisms**: the **IFC's Compliance Advisor Ombudsman (CAO)** and the **EBRD's independent complaint mechanism**, which investigate whether a financier's own standards were met — the CAO's findings on Amulsar's inadequate consultations and unassessed tourism impacts were a body-blow to the project. **Aarhus Centres** in Armenia, supported internationally, help communities use their environmental rights. None of these is a magic wand, but each is a real lever, and together they are formidable.

One more overseer is worth naming: **Armenia's own anti-corruption and audit institutions**, rebuilt and empowered after 2018, including specialised anti-corruption bodies and the Audit Chamber. Where a project rests on a captured decision, these are the bodies — alongside the Prosecutor's Office — that can investigate the arrangement behind it, and their post-2018 mandates make that a more credible threat than it was in the past.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns from how Armenian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project threatens water or a valued economy the public already cares about, whether the assessment has a real defect, whether the community's own bodies will resist, and how firmly the government backs the project. Where the water-and-tourism stakes are vivid and the financiers are international, Armenia's levers are unusually strong; where the government champions a strategic mine and issues the permits regardless, discount the figures and think in terms of delay, documented illegality, community resolutions, and international pressure.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Public participation in the EIA / expertise	15-35%	during review	low	On record; conditions, a redo, or a negative conclusion
Community-council & local resolutions	25-50%	ongoing	low	Local legitimacy stripped; project stalled or moved
Direct community presence / blockade	30-55%	ongoing	low-moderate	Access blocked; construction halted
Court challenge to the expert conclusion / permit	20-40%	12-36 months	low-moderate	Conclusion or permit quashed or reviewed; delay
Ombudsman referral	15-35%	6-24 months	low	Findings; scrutiny; pressure
International financier / accountability pressure	30-55%	6-36 months	low	Lenders exit; reputational and investor pressure
Documenting a legal violation (works without	25-45%	3-18	low	Breach exposed; leverage; possible sanction

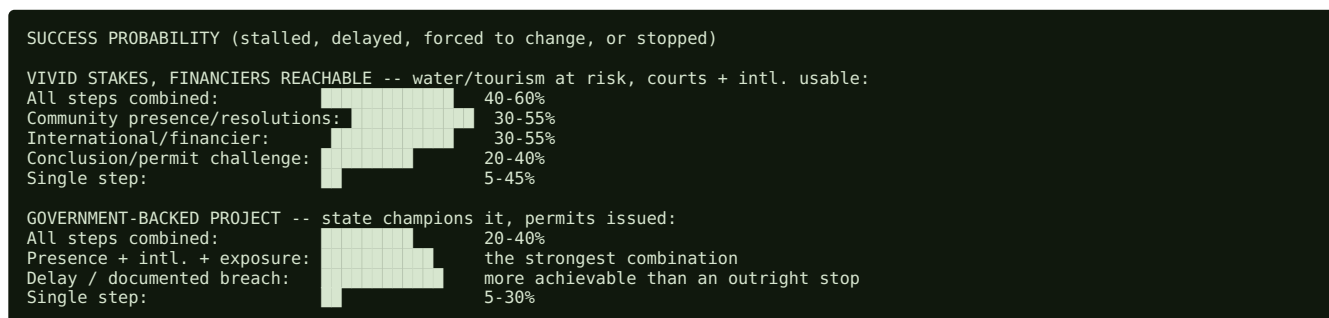
permit)		months		
Mass, connected public mobilisation	25-50%	6-36 months	low	Political cost; a project reconsidered
All steps combined (vivid stakes, financiers reachable)	40-60%	12-36 months	low-moderate	Stalled, delayed, or forced to change
All steps combined (government-backed, permits issued)	20-40%	12-48 months	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed, conditioned; rarely stopped outright

Key insight: all steps together beat any single one, and Armenia's real strengths are distinctive — a tradition of **physical community presence** that has actually halted a mine, **elected local bodies** that can withhold legitimacy, an **assessment law** with genuine public-participation and information rights, an **Aarhus Convention** guarantee of access to justice, **courts** that since 2018 are meaningfully more independent, an active **Ombudsman**, energetic **eco-NGOs and a free-ish press**, and — because the money is so often international — **unusually reachable financiers and accountability mechanisms**. Its constraints are a **mining-dependent economy**, a **government that backs strategic projects**, and the **investor-state arbitration threat** companies wield to pressure the state.

Weigh those honestly against your own project. A private mine with a defective assessment, an international lender, and a vivid water threat sits near the strong end of the range; a government-declared strategic project with permits already issued sits near the hard end. Most fights begin somewhere in the middle and move as the evidence, the money and the politics shift — so calibrate at the start, and recalibrate as you go.

A note on cost: participating, documenting, organising and reaching financiers are inexpensive, and Armenian NGOs, Aarhus Centres and international allies have supported community cases. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is committed legal support and the international campaign — both of which the Amulsar communities marshalled with striking effect.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Armenia are **rooted community presence and the international/financier spotlight**, reinforced by local resolutions, the conclusion-and-permit challenge, and documented violations. Amulsar shows the ceiling: communities physically blockaded a nearly finished mine, mobilised the world, triggered an international-ombudsman finding, and drove the IFC and EBRD out. It also shows the floor and the blowback: the government did not formally cancel the project, and the company answered with an investor-state arbitration threat. Most Armenian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that community presence and global attention are powerful, real levers — but against a government-backed project the realistic win is often delay, exposure, financier flight, and a company worn down, as much as an outright, permanent stop.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Rooted community presence and local legitimacy** — the physical presence, community-council resolutions, and refusal that a project cannot easily bypass; Armenia's distinctive and repeatedly decisive lever.
2. **The international and financier spotlight** — the lenders, accountability mechanisms and global press that an internationally financed project cannot escape.
3. **Documentation of violations and the assessment's defects** — the record, including any works without permit or any ignored water/tourism risk, that grounds every other step.
4. **The courts and the conclusion/permit challenge** — the legal route, real and, since 2018, more credible, best paired with the levers above.
5. **The Ombudsman, the eco-press, and mobilisation** — the further fronts that expose, pressure, and sustain.

What Armenian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Physical presence is real leverage** — the Jermuk and Gndevaz blockade of Amulsar's four access roads in June 2018 stopped a 75%-complete mine and held for over two years. **Local bodies matter** — collecting 3,000 signatures in five days and a council moving to ban metal mining stripped the project of local legitimacy. **The financiers can be reached** — the IFC withdrew and the EBRD exited, and the CAO ombudsman found the consultations inadequate and the tourism impacts unassessed. **Water and a treasured economy unite people** — a threat to Jermuk's mineral springs, the Kechut reservoir and, downstream, Lake Sevan bridged activists and residents. **But the government backs strategic projects** — officials publicly favoured the mine, and it was never formally cancelled. **And companies fight back through arbitration** — Lydian's threat of an investor-state claim was designed to pressure the state and chill resistance. The through-line: **build rooted presence and local resolutions, document every violation and every ignored risk, reach the financiers and the world, challenge the conclusion where you can — and expect a long fight measured in delay, exposure, financier flight, and a company worn down as much as an outright stop.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

You cannot fight what you have not precisely defined. Before anything else, pin down exactly what is proposed, who is behind it, where it is in the process, and where it is weak.

The Five Questions

1. What exactly is the project, and what will it do to the water? Name it precisely — a gold mine with cyanide heap leaching, a copper-molybdenum open pit with a tailings dam, a small hydropower plant on a river, a quarry, a landfill. Then trace the water pathway, because in Armenia water is almost always the decisive issue: what aquifer, spring, river or reservoir lies downhill or downstream, who drinks or irrigates from it, and what a spill, acid drainage or dust would do to it. At Amulsar the winning frame was that the mine sat above the water — threatening Jermuk's springs, the Kechut reservoir and, through it, Lake Sevan.

2. Who is behind it — operator, owner, and financier? Identify the operating company, its ultimate owners (often foreign or diaspora capital, sometimes behind local shells), and — critically — who lends or invests. An internationally financed or listed company has pressure points a purely domestic one lacks. Follow the money to the banks.

3. Where is it in the process, and what has it already got? Has it been categorised (A/B/C)? Has the assessment been submitted, consulted on, and given an expert conclusion? Does it hold a subsoil-use and mining permit, or a construction permit? The stage dictates your openings: before the conclusion, public participation and a negative conclusion are live; after, the challenge is to the conclusion and permits, plus violations and pressure. Amulsar is the cautionary tale here: the company held an early construction permit and had invested on the order of half a billion dollars and built the mine to roughly three-quarters completion *before* the community fully mobilised. The earlier you engage — ideally at categorisation and the first public consultation, not after the concrete is poured — the more openings you have and the cheaper each one is. If you are late, you are not lost, but you must lean harder on presence, violations, financier pressure and the international spotlight, because the paper openings have narrowed.

4. What does it legally require that it may not have? Every project needs a valid expert conclusion, genuine public consultation, and its permits. Where water, forests or a protected area are involved, additional consents apply. Ask what the law demands and whether it was truly satisfied — inadequate consultation, an assessment that ignored a real risk, or works begun without a permit are the classic, winnable defects.

5. Who is harmed, who benefits, and who decides? Map the affected communities, farmers, spa and tourism workers, and downstream users; the beneficiaries (company, investors, officials); and the decision-makers (the Ministry of Environment, the expertise body, the subsoil authority, the local council). This map is your coalition, your target list, and your pressure diagram.

Work the answers into a single page you can hand to anyone: the project in one line; the water and economy it threatens; the company, owners and financiers; the stage and permits; the legal defects; and the people affected. That page is the seed of your dossier, your press pitch and your objection all at once — and building it forces you to find, early, the gaps and pressure points the rest of the campaign will exploit.

Reading the Answers

If the project is Category A, its assessment has a visible hole (usually the water or a protected value), its finance is international, and its consultations were thin, you are in a strong position: participation, a conclusion challenge, financier pressure and mobilisation all point the same way. If the permits are issued, the government is committed, and the

assessment is technically complete, you are in the tilted situation — pivot to presence, resolutions, documented violations, and international pressure. Either way, the answers tell you which levers to pull first.

Naming Your Realistic Goal

Be clear-eyed about what winning means for you. It may be an outright stop; more often it is a negative or reconsidered conclusion, strict enforceable conditions, a smaller footprint, a moved site, or a delay long enough that the economics collapse or the financiers walk. Amulsar was not formally cancelled — but it was stopped on the ground for years and lost its international money. Name the goal you can actually reach, and aim every step at it.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the foundation of everything else. A campaign built on assertion collapses; a campaign built on a careful, dated, sourced record persuades regulators, survives in court, convinces the press, and reaches the financiers.

The Mindset: Build a Record for a Court and for the World

Assume from day one that your evidence may end up before the Administrative Court, the Ombudsman, an international financier's complaint mechanism, and a journalist. That standard — dated, sourced, verifiable, and safely stored — is what turns local knowledge into leverage. Keep everything: notices, the assessment, hearing records, your objections and their receipts, photographs, correspondence, and the official file.

What to Document

Document **the project and its permits**: the categorisation, the assessment report, the expert conclusion, the subsoil and construction permits, and their conditions. Document **the process**: every public notice (and every notice that should have appeared and did not), every hearing (who was invited, who spoke, what was recorded), and every objection you filed. Document **the harm and the risk**: the water pathway, the springs and reservoirs, the tourism and farming economy, the seismic and acid-drainage risks, the dust, and any early damage — at Amulsar, residents documented health complaints and livestock harm from the start of works. Be systematic about it: a simple shared log — date, what happened, where, who saw it, and the photograph or document that proves it — turns scattered observations into an evidentiary timeline that a court, a regulator and a reporter can all follow. Early harm, carefully recorded, is some of the most persuasive evidence a campaign can hold, because it answers the company's promise that nothing will go wrong with the fact that something already has. Document **the violations**: any clearing, drilling or building without the right permit, with dates, coordinates, photographs and, where possible, satellite imagery. Document **the money**: the operator, owners and financiers. In a mining fight, three documentary threads matter most and are worth building deliberately: the **water thread** (the hydrology, the pathway from mine to spring to reservoir, the acid-drainage and cyanide chemistry, and any monitoring data), the **process thread** (every notice, hearing, objection and reply, showing whether the law's participation duties were truly met), and the **money thread** (who owns, funds and profits, and to what standards their lenders hold them). A campaign that can pull any of these threads on demand — with dated, sourced documents — negotiates, litigates and publicises from strength.

How to Document Safely and Credibly

Photograph with date, time and location; keep originals; back everything up in more than one place, including outside the country if the situation is tense. Corroborate — a claim backed by the official document, a photograph and an independent report is far stronger than any one alone. Protect people: get consent before naming or filming residents, and be careful with anything that could expose a vulnerable person to retaliation. If you gather evidence of a violation, note how and when you obtained it, so its integrity cannot be attacked later. Keep a clean chain from observation to file: the raw photograph or document, the log entry that places it in time, and the finished exhibit that presents it. When a company or a ministry later disputes your account, that chain is what lets you answer, calmly, with the record.

A word on independent evidence: in Armenian mining fights the decisive documents have often been the ones the community commissioned or triggered itself — an independent hydrogeological or seismic review, a household health survey, or an international financier's own compliance investigation. These carry weight precisely because they do not come from the operator or the ministry. Where you can, pair the official record (which shows what was decided) with independent evidence (which shows what was ignored). That contrast — 'the assessment said the water was safe; here is the independent review that says it is not' — is what persuades a court, a lender and the public at once.

Reading an Armenian Expert Conclusion and Assessment for Its Weak Points

The assessment and the expert conclusion are where projects are most vulnerable. Read them against the real risks and ask: does the assessment actually analyse the **water** pathway — the aquifer, the springs, the reservoir, the acid mine drainage and cyanide risk — or wave it away? Does it assess the **existing economy** it threatens, especially tourism and spa water, or ignore it (the unassessed tourism impact was a formal finding against Amulsar)? Does it address **seismic** risk to a tailings dam in an earthquake-prone country? Were the **public consultations** genuine and timely, or informal, ad hoc and after the fact? Does the categorisation match the true scale? Each gap is both a ground for objection during the process and a ground for a court challenge to the conclusion afterwards.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Your case is only as strong as the sources behind it. Here is where the material lives and how to turn it into leverage.

The Official and Legal Record

Start with the **Ministry of Environment** and the **Environmental Impact Expert Examination Center**: the assessment report, the notices, the record of consultations, and the expert conclusion. Get the **subsoil-use and mining permit** and the **construction permit** and their conditions from the subsoil and construction authorities. Get the **local council's** records and any resolutions. Where you are refused or stonewalled, use the **Freedom of Information Law** (2003) to demand the file, and cite the **Aarhus Convention's** guarantee of access to environmental information — an unanswered or refused request is itself evidence of a closed process.

The Harm and Risk Sources

Bring in independent expertise on the risks the assessment minimises: hydrologists and geologists on the water and acid-drainage pathways; seismic engineers on tailings-dam safety; toxicologists on cyanide and heavy metals; economists on the tourism and agricultural value at stake. Armenian universities, the Academy of Sciences, and international experts have all contributed to community cases. A **health survey** of affected residents — as was done at Amulsar, where a large majority reported new illnesses after works began — is powerful, human evidence.

The Company and International Record

Research the operator and its owners through the company registry, and the financiers through the projects they disclose. For internationally financed projects, the lenders' own documents — the **IFC's** and **EBRD's** project pages, environmental and social assessments, and the reports of their **accountability mechanisms** — are gold: they set standards the project must meet and record where it failed. The CAO's Amulsar findings existed because residents filed a complaint; the mechanism is open to you.

Both the **IFC's Compliance Advisor Ombudsman** and the **EBRD's independent complaint mechanism** accept complaints from affected communities, examine whether the lender's environmental and social standards were met, and publish findings — and both processes reach the money directly. If your project has, or has ever had, IFC, EBRD, or other development-bank finance, treat their complaint mechanisms as a front-line tool, not an afterthought. Even after a lender exits, its findings remain on the public record as evidence.

The Organisations and Channels That Carry the Case

Armenia has experienced environmental organisations and outlets — **EcoLur**, the **Armenian Environmental Front** and allied groups, and international partners such as **CEE Bankwatch** — that have documented mining conflicts, supported communities, and reached the financiers. **Aarhus Centres** help residents use their information, participation and justice rights. These are your force-multipliers for research, legal support and reach. Do not overlook the **diaspora**. Armenia's global community follows environmental fights closely, funds and amplifies them, and reaches international media, parliaments and institutions that a village campaign could never access alone. A well-briefed diaspora network can turn a local water fight into a story in a dozen countries and a question in foreign capitals — a reach that bears directly on internationally financed projects and their reputations.

Turning Sources into a Case

Assemble the material into a short, sourced dossier: what is proposed, what it threatens (lead with the water), what the

law requires, where the assessment and process fall short, what has already gone wrong, and who is behind and financing it. Every claim carries its source. This one document becomes the spine of your objections, your court papers, your Ombudsman and financier complaints, and your press pack.

Researchers for Hire, and Everyday Research Tools

If you can fund it, environmental consultants and hydrogeologists can audit an assessment; investigative journalists can trace ownership and money; and public-records and corporate-intelligence specialists can map the financiers. For everyday work, learn to use the official registries and the lenders' disclosure portals, and use AI assistants and search tools to explain the law, summarise documents and draft — but verify every legal citation independently, because these tools invent references.

The Water Case — Where Local Meets Global

In Armenia the water pathway is where a local grievance becomes a national and international cause. A threat to a famous spa's springs, to a drinking-water reservoir, or — as at Amulsar — to the chain that feeds Lake Sevan, the country's great freshwater body, is a story that unites villagers, city-dwellers, scientists and the world's press. Build the water case with rigour and it becomes your master argument. In Armenia the water case also has a national dimension that reaches beyond any one town: Lake Sevan is a treasured national symbol and a critical freshwater store, and any credible threat to the chain that feeds it — as opponents argued at Amulsar, through the Kechut reservoir and the Arpa-Sevan system — turns a local grievance into a question the whole country feels it has a stake in. Where your project touches that chain, or a famous spring, or a river a region drinks from, say so plainly and prove it carefully; it is the argument most likely to make your fight everyone's fight.

The Financier and Investor Pressure Point

The single most decisive research task in many Armenian fights is to identify the money. An internationally financed project answers to lenders and shareholders who have reputational and compliance obligations, complaint mechanisms you can trigger, and the option to walk away — as the IFC and EBRD did at Amulsar. Find the financiers, learn their standards, document the breaches, and you have found the project's softest and most powerful pressure point.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence and law are levers, but people are the force that pulls them. In Armenia, organised community presence is not a supporting tactic — it is often the decisive one.

Start With a Small, Trusted Core

Begin with a handful of committed, trusted people who will carry the effort — residents, a respected local figure, a teacher, a farmer, a spa or tourism worker with something concrete to lose. Agree on the goal, divide the work (documentation, legal, media, outreach, logistics), and build from a solid centre outward. A rooted core that will not fold under pressure is worth more than a large, shallow crowd. Guard that core deliberately. Decide together, early, how far you are willing to go and what lines you will not cross; agree on non-violence and discipline if that is your path; and prepare for the pressure that will come — legal threats, security firms, offers and inducements, and attempts to divide you. Amulsar's communities faced private security and a corporate lawsuit threat and held together for years; that endurance came from a core that had agreed its terms in advance and trusted one another.

Widen Into a Rooted, Global Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in the neighbouring villages and the downstream users who share the water risk; the spa town or tourism businesses whose brand and livelihood are threatened; farmers and herders; the local council; scientists and doctors who can speak to the risk; Armenian eco-NGOs and Aarhus Centres; the diaspora, which cares deeply and can reach international media and institutions; and international allies who work on mining, water and financier accountability. The Amulsar coalition ran from Jermuk villagers to global conservation and human-rights attention — and that range is what made it impossible to ignore.

The Distinctive Armenian Levers — Presence and Local Legitimacy

Armenia's standout strengths are physical presence and local legitimacy. A **sustained community presence** at a site —

the Amulsar communities held blockades on the access roads for over two years — can physically halt construction in a way no letter can. A **local council resolution** and a **community petition** — Jermuk's council moving to ban metal mining, 3,000 signatures gathered in five days — strip a project of the local consent and legitimacy it needs. Used together, presence and legitimacy convert a paper fight into a fact on the ground.

The **Teghut** fight is the instructive counterpoint. For years, a civic movement opposed the clearing of the Teghut forest in Lori for a copper-molybdenum mine, warning about deforestation, water and the tailings dam. The forest was cleared and the mine opened — a hard reminder that presence and protest do not always prevail — but the mine was suspended within a few years amid tailings and financial troubles, and the campaign left a durable record and a trained movement. The lesson is twofold: rooted opposition does not guarantee a stop, but it builds the evidence, the networks and the public awareness that shape the next fight and that can outlast the project itself.

Choose Tactics That Fit — and Sustain the Effort

Match tactics to your capacity and to the law: public participation and objections; petitions and council resolutions; peaceful rallies and vigils; a sustained, well-organised site presence where that is your community's chosen path; and the legal and media fronts running in parallel. Whatever you choose, plan for the long haul — a serious project fight runs for years — and guard against burnout by sharing the load, rotating roles, and keeping the community's spirits and unity intact.

Hiring Help to Run the Campaign

If resources allow, professional help multiplies a volunteer effort. Campaign and communications professionals can run the media and messaging; organisers can train the coalition; and legal and technical experts can carry the specialist load. Insist on transparency and truth in everything — a manufactured or dishonest campaign is both wrong and, if exposed, fatal to your credibility. The goal is to run a professional, honest campaign, not a synthetic one.

The Community-Council and Referendum Lever

Because Armenia's local self-government has real competences and legitimacy, a community's own institutions are a distinctive front. A formal council resolution against a project, a locally organised consultation or petition, and public statements from elected local leaders carry political and moral weight that reaches Yerevan and the financiers. Where a community speaks, formally and united, through its own elected bodies, a project loses the social licence it needs.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

The law is one front among several — real, and since 2018 more credible in Armenia than in much of the region, but slow and uncertain. Use it in combination, not alone, and get proper counsel.

The Core Openings

The main legal targets are the **expert conclusion** and the **permits**. The environmental-assessment law expressly provides that disputes arising in the assessment and expertise process are appealed in court, and administrative acts — the conclusion, the subsoil and construction permits — can be challenged before the **Administrative Court**. The strongest grounds are procedural and substantive defects you documented in Step 2: inadequate or absent public consultation (an Aarhus and statutory breach), an assessment that ignored a real risk (the water pathway, seismic risk, the tourism economy), a mis-categorisation, or a permit issued without the necessary consents. Separately, **works carried out without the required permit** are unlawful and can be reported to the inspectorate and the prosecutor, and can support an injunction or sanction.

The Cost Risk — A Real Consideration

Litigation in Armenia is comparatively affordable — administrative court fees are modest — but it still carries costs in money, time and energy, and outcomes are uncertain. Get clear advice on fees, on the risk of paying the other side's costs if you lose, and on the realistic prospects before you commit. NGOs, Aarhus Centres and international allies have helped fund and staff community cases; do not assume you must bear it alone. Get counsel who knows environmental and administrative litigation specifically, not a generalist, and get them early enough to preserve deadlines and shape the record before it hardens. A lawyer brought in at the start can tell you which document to demand, which act to challenge, and which clock is already running; a lawyer brought in at the end can only work with what you left them.

Standing, Deadlines, and Realistic Expectations

Affected residents, communities and, in many cases, environmental organisations can bring administrative challenges — the Aarhus Convention supports broad access to justice in environmental matters. But **deadlines are strict**: an administrative act must usually be challenged within a defined, short period of learning of it, so act quickly and get advice on the clock the moment a conclusion or permit issues. Expect the process to take one to three years, and expect the most common realistic outcomes to be a quashed or reviewed conclusion, a remand for proper assessment or consultation, or a delay — rather than a guaranteed permanent stop.

What Legal Action Realistically Achieves

Even when a challenge does not end a project, it can suspend it, force a redo of a defective assessment, extract the full record, create binding findings you use elsewhere, and buy the time in which financiers reconsider and public pressure builds. The legal front is most powerful as the disciplined spine of a wider campaign — the thing that makes delay real and the defects official.

The Amulsar Precedent — What the Legal and Accountability Fronts Show

Amulsar's story on the legal and accountability fronts is instructive. Residents filed complaints to international financier mechanisms; the **CAO** found the consultations inadequate and the tourism impacts unassessed; the government commissioned an independent audit; and the project's legal status remained contested for years. It also shows the counter-move: the company threatened **investor-state arbitration** to pressure the government. The lesson is that the legal and accountability fronts — domestic courts, the Ombudsman, and the financiers' own mechanisms — are real and reinforcing, and that you should anticipate the arbitration threat as a pressure tactic rather than a reason to give up.

It is also worth knowing how the Amulsar company fared, because it reframes what 'winning' can mean. After the blockade held and the financiers withdrew, Lydian's corporate structure fell into insolvency and restructuring proceedings abroad; the government commissioned an independent technical audit of the project (by an international firm), whose contested findings became part of the public fight. None of this was a single clean court order — yet the combined weight of presence, lost finance and corporate distress did to the project what a verdict might not have. Read your own legal front the same way: a challenge that delays, suspends or forces a re-assessment can be decisive even if it never produces a headline judgment, because it buys the time in which the money and the momentum drain away.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

The same fact persuades different audiences in different languages. Translate your evidence deliberately for each.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that the assessment did not analyse the risk to the spa town's springs. To the **expertise body and the Ministry**, it is a legal defect that should block a positive conclusion. To a **court**, it is a ground to quash the conclusion. To the **Ombudsman**, it is a failure of due process and a rights concern. To a **financier's complaint mechanism**, it is a breach of the lender's own environmental and social standards. To the **press and the public**, it is proof that "they never even checked whether the mine would poison the water our town lives on." One fact; five arguments; five audiences moved.

Match the Argument to the Audience

- **Regulators and the expertise body** respond to legal duty and technical inadequacy: the assessment fails to meet the law's requirements; the conclusion cannot stand.
- **Courts** respond to procedure and rights: consultation was inadequate; a real risk went unassessed; the Aarhus and statutory duties were breached.
- **Local and national politicians** respond to legitimacy and cost: a united community opposes this; the town's economy and the country's water are at stake; backing it carries a political price.
- **Financiers and investors** respond to risk and reputation: this project breaches your standards, has drawn findings against it, and is a reputational and financial liability. Lenders and shareholders can absorb an environmental argument, but they move on a risk argument: a project that has attracted formal findings, litigation, a community blockade and international coverage is a liability on their books, and framing it that way is what turns a sympathetic banker into a departing one.

- **The public and the press** respond to people, place and fairness: our water, our town, our health — and they never asked.

The Master Frame: "Our Water, Our Town, and They Never Even Asked"

Above the specific arguments, hold one master frame — honest, human and repeated everywhere. In most Armenian fights it is some version of: **the project puts our water and our town's livelihood at risk, the people who live here never truly consented, and the checks that were supposed to protect us were skipped.** Water, home, and a broken promise of process — that frame carried Amulsar from a mountain village to the world.

Hold the master frame steady while you vary the supporting arguments, and resist the temptation to lead with the most technical point. Ministries and courts need the legal and technical version; the public and the financiers need the human and reputational one. The discipline is to keep saying the same true thing in each audience's language — the water, the town, the skipped consultation — so that a regulator, a judge, a lender and a reader all end up holding the same simple, damning picture from different angles.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media is not vanity; it is how you reach the decision-makers, the financiers, the courts of public opinion, and the allies you have not met yet. In Armenia, where the money is often international, media reach is directly a financier-pressure tool.

What Coverage Achieves

Coverage raises the political and reputational cost of a project, reaches investors and lenders who fear scandal, attracts legal and expert allies, protects activists by making them visible, and keeps a community's morale and unity strong. A remote mine becomes a national and international question the moment the story is told well.

Build the Story Around People, Place, and the Wrong Done

Lead with people and place, not process. The spa-town family whose spring is threatened; the herder whose livestock sickened; the scientist warning about the reservoir and Lake Sevan; the villagers standing on the road. Pair the human story with the hard evidence — the ignored risk, the skipped consultation, the financier's own findings — so the coverage is both moving and unanswerable.

Reach Every Layer

Work every layer: local and national Armenian outlets and the strong eco-press (EcoLur and allied outlets); the diaspora media, which amplifies internationally; international press and wire services, especially where water, cyanide, or a treasured landscape are involved; and social media to organise, document and reach directly. The Amulsar blockade became global news — and that reach is what put the financiers under pressure.

Time your media, too. A hearing, a permit decision, a court date, a financier's board meeting, an anniversary of the fight — each is a natural news peg that lets you put the story in front of the exact decision-maker at the moment it matters. And keep a steady drumbeat between peaks: a regular flow of documented developments keeps a remote fight alive in the national and diaspora press and signals to the money that the reputational problem is not going away.

Discipline and Safety

Stay accurate and disciplined: never publish a claim you cannot back, correct errors fast, and keep the message consistent. Protect people — get consent before featuring residents, and be mindful of retaliation risk. Designate a few trained spokespeople so the campaign speaks with one credible voice.

Amplifying at Scale — Media Help for Hire

If you can, bring in communications professionals and public-interest media specialists to run the press operation, place stories, and reach international outlets and the financiers — always transparently and truthfully. Professional amplification, done honestly, can turn a local story into the international cause that changes a project's economics.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you enter objections, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence.

8A. Objection During the EIA / Expertise Process

To: the Ministry of Environment / the Environmental Impact Expert Examination Center **Subject:** Objection — [project], environmental impact assessment [ref]

As a person affected by [project] at [location], I object during the environmental impact assessment and expertise process. My grounds, with evidence: (1) the assessment [omits / understates] [effect — e.g. the risk to the springs, the reservoir and, downstream, the water supply, including acid mine drainage and cyanide]; (2) it fails to assess [the tourism / spa economy the project threatens]; (3) the public consultations were [inadequate / not genuinely held], contrary to the Law on Environmental Impact Assessment and Expertise and the Aarhus Convention. I request that a **negative expert conclusion** issue, or that [a full re-assessment and genuine consultation] be required, and that this objection be entered on the record. [Attachments.]

8B. Request for Information

To: [the Ministry of Environment / the expertise body / the subsoil authority] **Subject:** Request for information — [project]

Under the Freedom of Information Law and the Aarhus Convention, I request copies of: the environmental impact assessment; the expert conclusion; the subsoil-use, mining and construction permits and their conditions; the public notices and the record of consultations; and the correspondence relating to [water / land / protected-area consents]. As an affected resident, I ask that these be provided within the period the law allows.

8C. Community-Council Resolution / Statement of Local Opposition

To: [the community council / the provincial administration], copied to the Ministry of Environment **Subject:** Resolution of the community of [name] regarding [project]

The community of [name], through its elected council, resolves that it opposes [project] at [location] on the grounds of [the threat to our water, health, and local economy], and that its consent to [the use of local land / the project] is **withheld**. We call on the authorities to [refuse the expert conclusion / withhold the permits] and to respect the position of the affected community. [Record of the vote / petition attached.]

8D. Court Challenge to the Conclusion or Permit (via counsel / an Aarhus Centre or NGO)

To: [the Administrative Court], through counsel **Subject:** Application to challenge [the expert conclusion / the permit] — [project]

The applicants, affected residents and [organisation], challenge [the expert conclusion / the subsoil / construction permit] for [project] as unlawful, on the grounds that: (1) the public consultation required by law and the Aarhus Convention was inadequate; (2) the assessment failed to assess [the water pathway / seismic risk / the tourism economy]; (3) [the categorisation was wrong / a required consent was absent]. We seek [annulment / suspension / remand for proper assessment]. [Grounds and evidence attached.]

8E. Referral to the Human Rights Defender (Ombudsman)

To: the Human Rights Defender of the Republic of Armenia **Subject:** Complaint — [project], environmental and due-process concerns

I ask the Defender to examine [project] at [location]. The affected community's rights to a healthy environment, to information, and to genuine participation were not respected: [the consultation was inadequate; information was refused; a real risk to our water and health was ignored]. I ask the Defender to investigate and to issue findings and recommendations. [Evidence attached.]

8F. Letter to the Minister of Environment

To: the Minister of Environment **Subject:** [project] — request to refuse the conclusion / halt the works

I write on behalf of the affected community of [location]. [Project] threatens [our water, our health, and our local economy], its assessment is defective in [ways], and its consultations were inadequate. We are a community united in opposition, and we ask you to stand with the people whose water and livelihoods are at stake rather than with a project that skipped the checks meant to protect them. We ask you to [ensure a negative expert conclusion / withhold or review the permits / order an inspection of works carried out without permit] and to meet the affected community. [Evidence attached.]

8G. Coalition / Financier Outreach Email (to an NGO, Aarhus Centre, or a project's lender)

To: [EcoLur / the Armenian Environmental Front / CEE Bankwatch / the financier's complaint mechanism] **Subject:** Support / complaint — [project], [location]

Our community is opposing [project], which threatens [water / health / a spa economy] and whose assessment and consultation were defective. [To an ally:] we ask for [legal / technical / media] support and for help reaching [the press / the financiers]. [To a lender's mechanism:] we submit that the project breaches [the lender's] environmental and social standards in [ways], and we request an investigation. [Dossier attached.]

8H. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** A mine above the water our town lives on — [location], Armenia

I can offer a story: [project] would put [the springs / reservoir / Lake Sevan's water] and our town's livelihood at risk; the people who live here never truly consented; and the checks meant to protect us were skipped — [the water risk was not assessed; the consultations were inadequate; the financiers' own review found failings]. I can connect you with affected residents and provide documents and images. [Contact.]

Using the Templates Well

Adapt each to your facts; verify the current name and address of every body before you send; attach your evidence; keep copies and proof of delivery; and be precise and factual. A specific, sourced, dated letter is both a request and a piece of the record you are building.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With an afternoon a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find the water risk — today.** Work out exactly what spring, reservoir, river or aquifer the project threatens, and who depends on it. In Armenia this single fact is usually the heart of the whole fight.
- 2. Get your community on record.** A council resolution or a petition (8C) that opposes the project and withholds local consent strips it of legitimacy and creates a powerful record — as Jermuk's did at Amulsar. This is often the single highest-impact move.
- 3. Object during the assessment, and demand the file.** One objection (8A) during the public-participation window and one information request (8B) put your concerns on the record and force out the assessment, the conclusion and the permits — often revealing the defect or the skipped consultation that becomes your case.
- 4. Document any violation.** If the company has cleared, drilled or built without the right permit, record it — dates, coordinates, photographs, satellite imagery — and report it to the inspectorate and prosecutor.
- 5. Reach an ally.** An Armenian eco-NGO or Aarhus Centre (8G) can bring legal, technical and media support fast, and advise on the court option and its costs.
- 6. Reach the financiers and the press.** If the project is internationally financed, a complaint to the lender's mechanism

and a single accurate tip to a journalist (8H) can turn a remote fight into an international cause and put the money under pressure — as happened at Amulsar.

7. Refer it to the Ombudsman. A referral (8E) brings scrutiny without the cost and delay of court.

8. Keep it going. Even an afternoon a week, sustained, beats a burst that fades. A steady trickle of objections, information requests, logged violations and press tips signals to the company and the ministry that the problem is permanent — and permanence is what wears a project down.

Do only the first three and you will have named the water risk, put your community on record, withheld consent, and forced out the file — the exact combination that has most tested projects in Armenia. Then come back and read the rest.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Sometimes the deck is stacked: the government calls the project strategic, the permits are issued, and officials publicly champion it. Be honest that this changes the odds — and know that Armenia has still moved projects in exactly this situation.

Where the Tilt Shows

You will feel the tilt when the assessment sails through despite obvious gaps; when consultations are held but treated as a formality; when officials dismiss concerns before the process ends; when the inspectorate is slow to act on works without permit; and when the company answers opposition with the threat of an investor-state arbitration claim aimed at the government. These are signs that the ordinary process alone will not save you, and that you must shift your weight to the levers the state cannot as easily control. The mindset shift is important: stop trying to win the argument inside a body that has already decided, and start raising the project's cost outside it. Every documented violation, every lender put on notice, every headline and every day of delay is a brick removed from a project that officialdom is trying to keep standing.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

Even tilted, several levers keep force, and some are Armenia's strongest. **Physical community presence** does not depend on a favourable official — the Amulsar blockade halted a nearly finished, government-favoured mine for years by standing on the roads. **Local legitimacy** — council resolutions, petitions, a united community — cannot be issued away by a ministry. **Documented illegality** — works without permit, ignored risks — bites regardless of who favours the project, because it exposes the state's own failure to enforce its law. **International financier and accountability pressure** reaches money that answers to standards and shareholders, not to the Armenian cabinet — the IFC and EBRD left Amulsar. And **the international spotlight**, especially on water and cyanide, raises a cost the government feels. Against a government-backed project the realistic aim becomes delay, exposure, financier flight, strict conditions, and a company worn down — and those are real outcomes, not consolation prizes.

The Honest Frame

If the system is tilted, tell your community the truth: an outright legal stop is less likely, but presence, legitimacy, documented illegality, financier pressure and global attention have repeatedly forced government-favoured projects to stall, shrink or lose their money. Aim there, sustain it, and keep an unimpeachable record — because in a tilted fight your credibility and your persistence are your greatest assets.

One specific tilted-situation tactic deserves emphasis: **anticipate and neutralise the arbitration threat**. When a company warns of a multi-billion investor-state claim, its real audience is the government, and its aim is to make listening to you look expensive. You counter it by making the *project* look expensive and risky too — through documented illegality, financier flight, reputational damage and delay — and by pointing out, publicly, that a state should not surrender its own environmental law and its citizens' water to the fear of a corporate lawsuit. The threat is a pressure tactic; met with equal and opposite pressure, it loses much of its force.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sometimes the problem is not merely a tilted policy but capture: the decision has been bought or arranged, and the

process is theatre. Armenia's 2018 change came precisely as a revolt against entrenched corruption, and the mining sector was among its longstanding concerns — so this is familiar ground, and there is now more space to expose it than there once was.

Signs of Capture

Watch for a rushed or waved-through assessment despite serious gaps; consultations that are announced but not genuinely held; permits granted against clear evidence of harm; officials or their relatives with interests in the operator; a company shielded from an inspectorate that acts against others; and public officials advocating for a private project as if it were their own. Undisclosed ownership behind local shells, and revolving doors between the regulator and the industry, are the classic tells.

Armenia's mining sector carried, for years, exactly these features — opaque ownership, cosy ties between operators and officials, and permits that seemed to precede the assessments meant to justify them — and the 2018 revolution was, in part, a reaction against that order. That history cuts two ways for you: it means capture is a real and familiar risk, but it also means there is now a public appetite to expose it, institutions with fresh mandates to investigate it, and a press and civil society practised at pursuing it. Where you can show that a decision was arranged rather than reasoned, you are pushing on a door that recent Armenian politics has already begun to open.

Why This Changes Your Strategy

Where the decision is captured, persuading the captured body is pointless — you must go around and above it. Shift to the levers outside its control: the courts and the Ombudsman; the **Prosecutor's Office**, the **Audit Chamber** and anti-corruption bodies, which since 2018 have real mandates; the financiers and their accountability mechanisms, which answer to their own standards; the National Assembly and its committees; and the press and the public. Corruption is itself a story and a vulnerability — exposing the capture can be more decisive than arguing the environmental merits.

Document It Carefully and Safely

Gather proof of capture with special care: the undisclosed interest, the waved-through step, the official acting for the company, the ignored evidence — dated, sourced, and safely stored, with copies held securely, including outside the country if needed. Be mindful of your safety and get legal advice before making public allegations. Then route the evidence to the bodies and the journalists that can act on it. But handle it as evidence, not as a slogan: an allegation you cannot prove damages your credibility and can expose you to legal risk, while a documented arrangement — the interest, the step, the beneficiary, all sourced — is nearly unanswerable. Prove it, protect yourself, and place it where it will be acted on. Handled carefully, proof of corruption is one of the most powerful things a campaign can hold.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The strands only reach their full force when woven together and sustained over time.

How the Strands Reinforce Each Other

Documentation grounds the objections; the objections build the court case, the Ombudsman complaint and the financier complaint; the community's presence and resolutions supply legitimacy and physical leverage; the media carries all of it to the public and the money; and the international and financier pressure converts local resistance into a cost the project cannot absorb. A defect you document becomes a legal ground, an Ombudsman finding, a financier breach and a headline at once. Pull one thread and the others tighten. Amulsar is the model: documentation, health evidence, community presence, local resolutions, court and complaint filings, financier accountability, and global media, all at once — and the IFC and EBRD walked, and the mine stood still.

A Rough Timeline

Weeks 1-4: identify the project precisely; find the water risk; get the assessment, conclusion and permits; build your small core; begin the record. **Months 2-4:** file your objections and information requests during the assessment; pass a council resolution or petition; widen the coalition; bring in expert allies; document any violation; open the media front. **Months 4-12:** if a conclusion or permit issues, challenge it in the Administrative Court within the deadline; refer to the Ombudsman; file complaints to the financiers' mechanisms; escalate the media and international campaign; sustain community presence where that is your path. **Year 2 and beyond:** carry the legal and accountability processes through;

keep the pressure on the money and the reputation; hold the community together; and adapt as the government's stance and the company's finances shift. Expect a fight measured in years — Amulsar's blockade alone lasted over two.

Pace yourself for that horizon from the beginning. Build in rotation so no one person carries the campaign; celebrate the interim wins — a forced re-assessment, a lender's exit, a strong hearing — so the community sees progress; keep the record continuous so a two-year gap does not lose the thread; and prepare successors, because in a multi-year fight people move, tire and change. The campaigns that endure are the ones that treat endurance itself as a task to be organised, not a virtue to be hoped for.

Delay, Exposure, and a Company Worn Down — The Amulsar Lessons

Amulsar teaches the deepest lesson about time. The community did not win a single clean courtroom victory that ended the mine; it won by making the project slower, costlier, riskier and more embarrassing month after month until its international financiers left and its economics broke down. Delay is not failure — it is often the mechanism of the win. A project stalled long enough loses its money, its momentum and its investors' patience. Build for endurance, and let time do part of the work. There is a hard corollary: the company knows this too, and its counter-strategy is to move fast, to fracture your unity, and to wait you out in turn. So the contest becomes, in part, a test of stamina and cohesion — which is why the organising and morale work of Section 7 is not soft accompaniment to the 'real' legal and technical fight but a load-bearing part of it. The community that stays united and funded and rested outlasts the project; the one that burns out hands the company its victory by default.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

The Honest Bottom Line

Communities in Armenia can and do change the fate of destructive projects — but usually through combined, sustained pressure rather than a single decisive blow, and more often by stalling, exposing, shrinking, conditioning, or draining the money from a project than by winning a clean, permanent legal stop. The levers are real and, in Armenia, unusually powerful: physical presence that has halted a nearly finished mine, elected local bodies that can withhold legitimacy, an assessment law with genuine participation rights, Aarhus-backed access to justice, courts more independent since 2018, an active Ombudsman, energetic eco-NGOs and press, and — because the money is so often international — remarkably reachable financiers and accountability mechanisms. The constraints are equally real: a mining-dependent economy, a government that backs strategic projects, and the investor-state arbitration threat companies use to pressure the state.

What Distinguishes the Campaigns That Win

The campaigns that succeed tend to share the same traits. They **lead with the water** and the shared, tangible stakes that unite people. They **root themselves locally** and speak through the community's own bodies. They **maintain presence and legitimacy** the state cannot simply overrule. They **document everything** to a standard that survives in court, before the Ombudsman, at the financier, and in the press. They **find and pressure the money**, triggering the accountability mechanisms and driving lenders away. They **combine fronts** rather than betting on one. And they **endure**, understanding that delay, exposure and financier flight are how most of these fights are actually won.

A Closing Word

If you are facing a destructive project, know that the outcome is not written in advance. The people of Jermuk and Gndevaz stood on four mountain roads and stopped a mine that powerful people were sure would open. You may not have their exact levers, but you have some version of them — the water, your community, your voice, your record, and a world that can be reached. Use them together, tell the truth, protect each other, and hold on. That combination has changed what looked unchangeable before, in Armenia and beyond. The mountain roads above Amulsar are the proof: a handful of villages, standing on the ground they knew best, changed the fate of a mine that money and power had all but finished. What they had, you have some version of — and combined, sustained, and told truthfully, it is more than enough to be worth the fight.

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

Winning rarely looks like a single triumphant verdict. It looks like a negative or reconsidered expert conclusion; a defective assessment sent back to be done properly; enforceable conditions that shrink the harm; a project moved away from the water; construction halted on the ground; an inspectorate and prosecutor forced to act on illegal works; the IFC and EBRD

walking away, as they did at Amulsar; a company's finances and patience worn down until the project collapses of its own weight; and — sometimes — an outright stop. Each of these is a real win. Name the one you can reach, combine every front to reach it, and sustain the effort until the balance tips your way.

And remember what the map in front of you is for: it exists so that the next community does not have to start from nothing. Every objection filed, every violation logged, every financier complaint lodged, every story told, adds to a body of knowledge and a network of allies that the fight after yours will inherit. Whether your own project is stopped, shrunk, delayed or merely exposed, you will have made the ground firmer for the people who come after — and in a small country where the same companies, ministries and rivers recur from one fight to the next, that inheritance is itself a form of winning.